The Opposition's Journey

Deepening Roots (1968-2025)

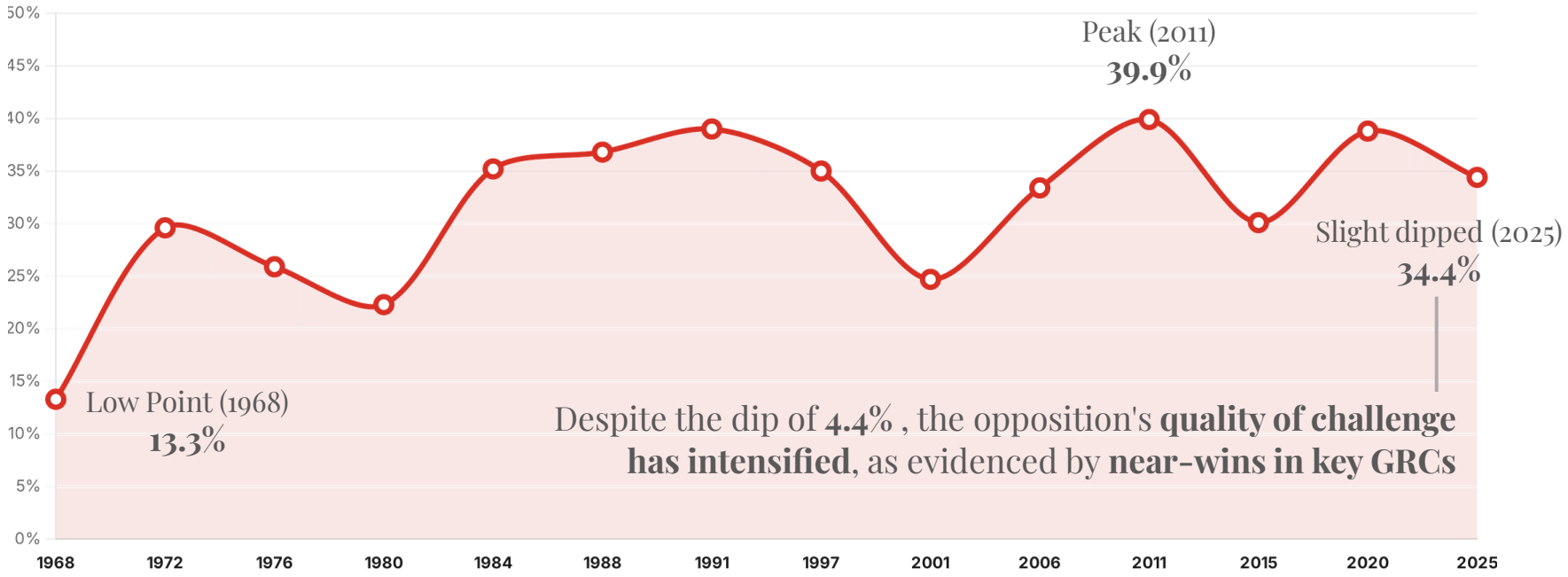
The Shift from Quantity to Quality

Data Journalism Team

27 February 2026

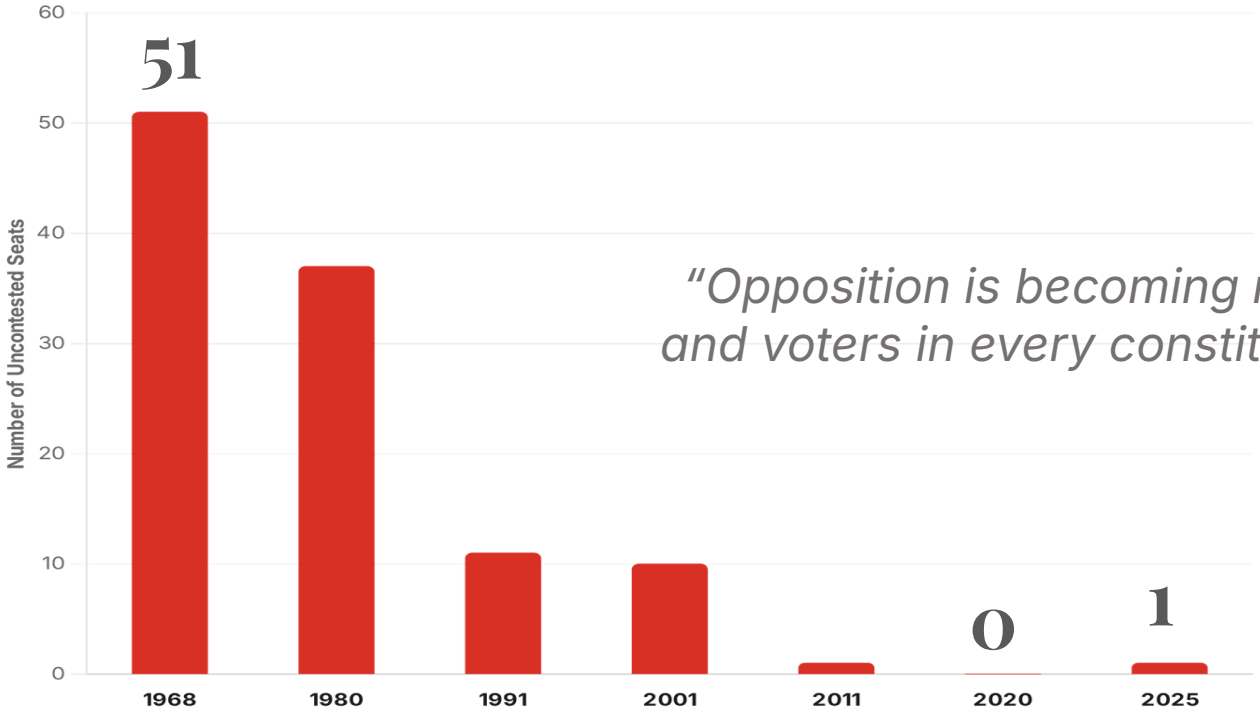
From Margin to Permanent Force

Opposition Vote Share (1968-2025)



The End of Walkover Era

From 51 (1968) to 1 Uncontested Seats (2025)



"Opposition is becoming more professional, and voters in every constituency now have a choice"

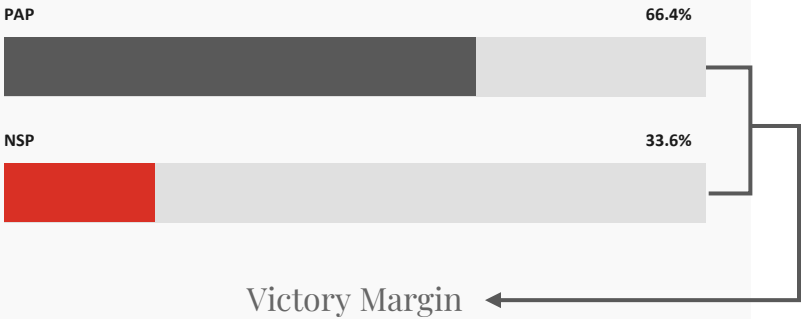
The Tampines Earthquake

Case Study: How competition impacted margins (2020 – 2025)

"In Tampines, the presence of multiple opposition parties coincided with a dramatic margin collapse, suggesting voters consolidated behind the strongest challenger."

2020

SAFE FORTRESS (2-Cornered)

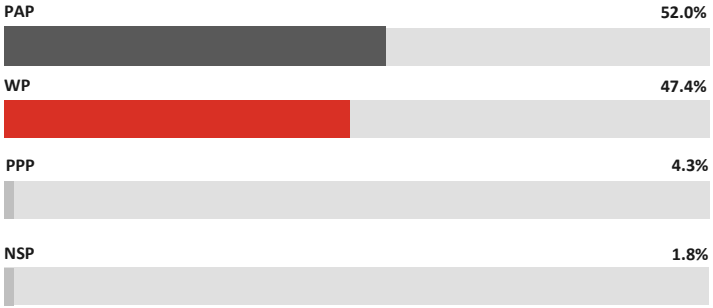


Victory Margin

32.8%

2025

BATTLEGROUND (4-Cornered)



Victory Margin

4.6%

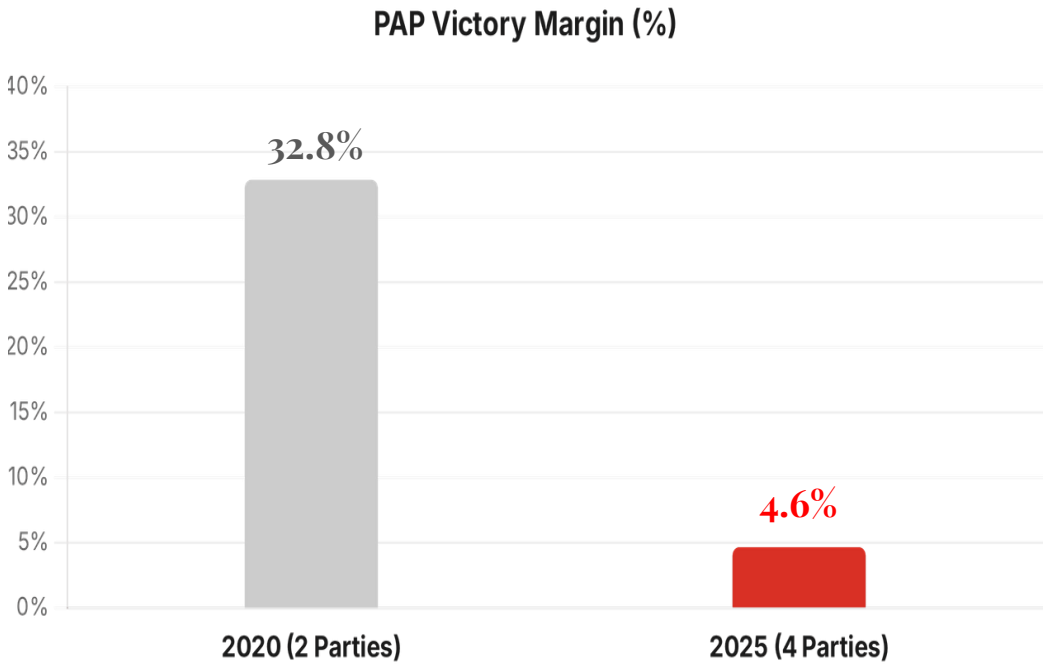
More choices, Lower PAP Margins

The Multi-Cornered Effect

Increased Competition Erodes Lead in Tampines

Moving from a 2-cornered to a 4-cornered fight led coincided with a dramatic collapse in the victory margin.

> *"More opposition flags on the ground signaled a stronger collective desire for change."*



2025: The Independent Surge

Voters choose **quality candidates** over party labels

36.2%

Jeremy Tan

Mountbatten SMC

23.5%

Darryl Lo

Radin Mas SMC

Highest Independent results since the 1990s

Surpassing the typical ~ 10 – 15% range for Non-party candidates

WP Consolidation: Quality Over Quantity

Deepening Roots in Key Strongholds

Sengkang GRC

56.3%

↑ +4.2% from 2020

Hougang SMC

62.2%

↑ +0.9% from 2020

> **Key Insight:** Despite a **4.4%** dip in the national opposition vote, the Workers' Party (WP) actually grew its mandate in existing strongholds.

Strategic Shift: Credibility is Currency

The Fight to Quality

The Old Model (1960s - 2000s)

- "Any Opposition Will Do"
- Scattershot Contests
- Protest Voting

The New Reality (2000s – 2025~)

- Credible Alternatives Only
- Targeted Strongholds
- Mandate Voting

"Voters now punish dilution and reward competence."

The Playbook for 2029/2030

Strategic Imperatives for the Next General Election – Opposition Team

01

Choose Battle Wisely.

Don't fear competition, but be **strategic**. In some cases, a crowded field may concentrate 'change' vote behind a single alternative.

02

Quality Over Quantity

Voters distinguish signal from noise. Field **fewer, highly credible professionals** rather than filling quotas with placeholder candidates.

03

Target the Fortresses

Focus resources on key marginal GRCs/SMCs:

- **Jalan Kayu SMC - WP** *(Margin: 2.9%)*
- **Tampines GRC - WP** *(Margin: 4.6%)*
- **Sembawang West SMC - SDP** *(Margin: 6.3%)*

2029/2030

The Tipping Point?

The opposition has moved from 'showing up' to 'showing worth'.